About Varun Nimbolkar

Born in May 1990 and based in Pune, India, Varun Nimbolkar is a pioneering composer, producer, performing sitar player, and vocalist in the independent music space. Trained under legendary masters—including over a decade under Ustad Usman Khan, time with Pt. Vijay Koparkar, and mentorship under Pt. Kushal Das—Varun bridges deep-rooted Indian classical traditions with contemporary global genres.

A Modern Vision for the Sitar

Varun experiments extensively with acoustic and electric sitar coupled with FX pedals, weaving original electronic music, ambient soundscapes, and groovy beats. Critics have praised his cinematic approach; ***HomeGrown*** observed, “Nimbolkar's artistic vision owes more to composers like *Nitin Sawhney* than to the traditional 'world music' lineage... His work sits at the intersection of sound design and storytelling, rooted, yet exploratory.”while ***The Indian Music Diaries*** described his artistry as a *"captivating collision of lyrical narratives and the melodic mystique of Sitar-based instrumentals."* His eclectic discography includes the exploratory EPs ***Bah Bah Black Sheep*** and ***Dreams for a Living***, alongside singles like *Watching Her Dance* (featured in *Rolling Stone India* and on FabIndia store playlists).

Pioneering Live Performances & Global Reach

As a live act, Varun is a true trailblazer: he is the first artist to perform original sitar compositions in nightclubs across most major Indian cities, establishing himself as a pioneer in indie sound and presentation.

His live presence extends across elite stages worldwide:

- **National Milestones:** Following a 6-city India tour, he featured on the prestigious *Magnetic Music* lineup at ZLB (Bangalore) alongside acts like Indian Ocean and Rajasthani Roots.
- **International Expansion:** His May 2026 UK tour brought solo sitar and ethnic electronica sets to Manchester and London, including a 90-minute headline performance at **The Nehru Centre** (High Commission of India) and main-stage appearances at the **Mind Body Spirit Festival**, **Happy Place Festival**, and **World Yoga Festival**.
- **Live IPs:** He performs full-ensemble shows under his live IP **'The Sitara Devi Project'**, backed by his band, **The Sitara Devi & her Bois**.

Tours & Stages

Varun Nimbolkar's live performances transcend traditional concert settings, functioning as immersive, multi-sensory experiences where the acoustic and electric sitar meets live electronic production, FX pedals, ambient soundscapes, and hypnotic grooves. Whether commanding major international festival stages or intimate cultural venues, Varun brings his music to life through two distinct live setups:

- **Solo Sets:** Intimate, cutting-edge explorations of ethnic electronica, ambient soundscapes, and live looping.
- **The Sitara Devi Project:** His comprehensive live touring IP, featuring high-energy, full-ensemble band performances brought to the stage by **The Sitara Devi & her Bois**.

International Expansion: The UK Tour

In May 2026, Varun embarked on his landmark **first UK tour**, taking his signature blend of sitar-led electronica to audiences across Manchester and London.

- **The Nehru Centre:** Delivered a prestigious 90-minute headline solo performance at the cultural wing of the High Commission of India in London.
- **Major Wellness & Arts Festivals:** Performed main-stage sets at prominent UK cultural gatherings, including:
    - **Mind Body Spirit Festival 2026**
    - **Happy Place Festival 2026**
    - **World Yoga Festival 2026**

National Footprint & Curated Festival Highlights

Across India, Varun has built a reputation for riveting live shows, anchored by expansive touring and elite festival curation.

- **6-City India Tour:** Following consecutive album and EP releases, Varun completed an extensive 6-city national tour, bringing his genre-defying sound to dedicated indie music audiences across the country.
- **Magnetic Music at ZLB (The Leela Palace, Bengaluru):** Varun was featured on the star-studded lineup of the prestigious *Magnetic Music* series (curated by ZLB23), sharing festival rosters and high-profile stages alongside iconic torchbearers of Indian fusion like **Indian Ocean** and **Rajasthani Roots**.
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Collaborations & Production Work

Beyond his solo discography and live touring, Varun Nimbolkar is an active collaborator, composer, and session artist. Blending the sitar with diverse genres—from hip-hop and electronica to blues rock and indie-pop—Varun frequently partners with independent artists, record labels, brands, and film creators to inject unique acoustic and electronic textures into modern productions.

Notable Artist Collaborations & Features

- **"Thoda Sa" (Gunda feat. Varun Nimbolkar & Unkill ji):** Contributed signature sitar work and production to the track "Thoda Sa" by Gunda, released via the prominent indie label **Azadi Records**.
- **Collaborations with Tienas:** Partnered with hip-hop/indie artist Tienas on cross-genre music projects, blending intricate sitar dynamics with contemporary urban beats.
- **Collaborations with Amritha Thankachy:** Joined forces with singer-composer Amritha Thankachy, merging Hindustani/Carnatic sensibilities with contemporary production styles.
- **"Maya" (Derek & The Cats):** Featured artist on the track "Maya" from the album *People to Meet, Places to See*.
- **"The Unposted Letter":** A collaborative single featuring vocalist Saee Tembhekar, which received widespread acclaim across *Rockstreet Journal* (RSJ Buzz) and *Rolling Stone India*.

Brand Partnerships & In-Store Curation

- **FabIndia:** His acoustic track *"Watching Her Dance"* was selected by FabIndia to be played across all of its retail stores throughout India for a continuous 12-month period as part of their curated in-store playlist.

Sound Design & AI Music Innovation

- **Beatoven AI:** Contributed a custom library of over 400 Sitar-based loops and phrases for the sample library of *Beatoven*, an innovative AI-driven music composition software designed for creators and filmmakers.

Streaming & Audience Metrics

- **400,000+** — All-time total streams across major digital platforms (including catalog numbers under *The Ashwatth Project* alias).
- **16,000+** — Peak monthly listeners across Spotify and streaming networks.
- **1,300+** — Dedicated followers tuning into the independent catalog.

Commercial Sync & Retail Footprint

- **12 Months** — Continuous nationwide in-store rotation for the acoustic single *"Watching Her Dance"*, selected by **FabIndia** to play across all retail outlets in India.

Listen & Connect

Immerse yourself in Varun Nimbolkar's genre-defying soundscapes, EPs, and live performance visuals across digital streaming and social platforms.

Streaming Platforms

- **Spotify:** Stream EPs like *Bah Bah Black Sheep* and *Dreams for a Living* on Varun Nimbolkar's Spotify Artist Profile[cite: 1].
- **Apple Music:** Listen to original releases and singles on Varun Nimbolkar on Apple Music.

Video & Visuals

- **YouTube:** Watch live performance sets, music videos, and visualizers on Varun Nimbolkar's YouTube Channel.

Social & Community

- **Instagram:** Keep up with behind-the-scenes studio sessions, tour updates, and live clips by following @varun_nimbolkar[cite: 1].
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Press & Media Coverage

Explore reviews, features, and critical coverage highlighting Varun Nimbolkar's genre-blending releases, experimental sitar compositions, and live performances across the indie landscape.

Featured Reviews & Publications

- **Homegrown Magazine (October 2025)**
  - **Article:** Varun Nimbolkar's Indian Experimental Fusion EP Doubles Down On Emotive Storytelling
  - *Excerpt:* A deep-dive feature on the 5-track exploratory EP *Bah Bah Black Sheep*, noting how Varun treats fusion as a structural storytelling principle rather than an ornamental crossover.
- **The Indian Music Diaries (October 2025)**
  - **Article:** Varun Nimbolkar's 'Bah Bah Black Sheep' Sits Comfortably Between Indian Classical and Electronica
  - *Excerpt:* A glowing review by Krishangi Sarma exploring how Varun weaves classical foundations with electronic textures to carve a unique niche in the indie circuit.
- **The Indian Music Diaries (January 2024)**
  - **Article:** Varun Nimbolkar's "Dreams For A Living" EP Melds Classical Essence With Rock Resonance
  - *Excerpt:* Reviewed by Madhulika Gupta, celebrating the EP as a kaleidoscopic journey where ancient sitar strings resonate with rock and blues resonance.
- **Homegrown Magazine (February 2026)**
  - **Article:** Art That Inspires: 7 Homegrown Musicians On The Books That Shaped Their Sound
  - *Excerpt:* An artist feature exploring the literary influences behind Varun's emotive compositions and single *Amrita*.
- **The Indian Music Diaries (June 2021)**
  - **Article:** Singles Roundup #29: Diversify Your Playlist With These Latest Tracks
  - *Excerpt:* Early critical recognition highlighting the seamless blend of Indian classical and electronica on debut single *Watching Her Dance*.
- **The Indian Music Diaries (Album Review)**
  - **Article:** Derek & The Cats' 'People to Meet, Places to See' is a Record Both You and Your Dad Can Dance To
  - *Excerpt:* Highlighted feature review emphasizing Varun's guest sitar contributions elevating the track *Maya*.